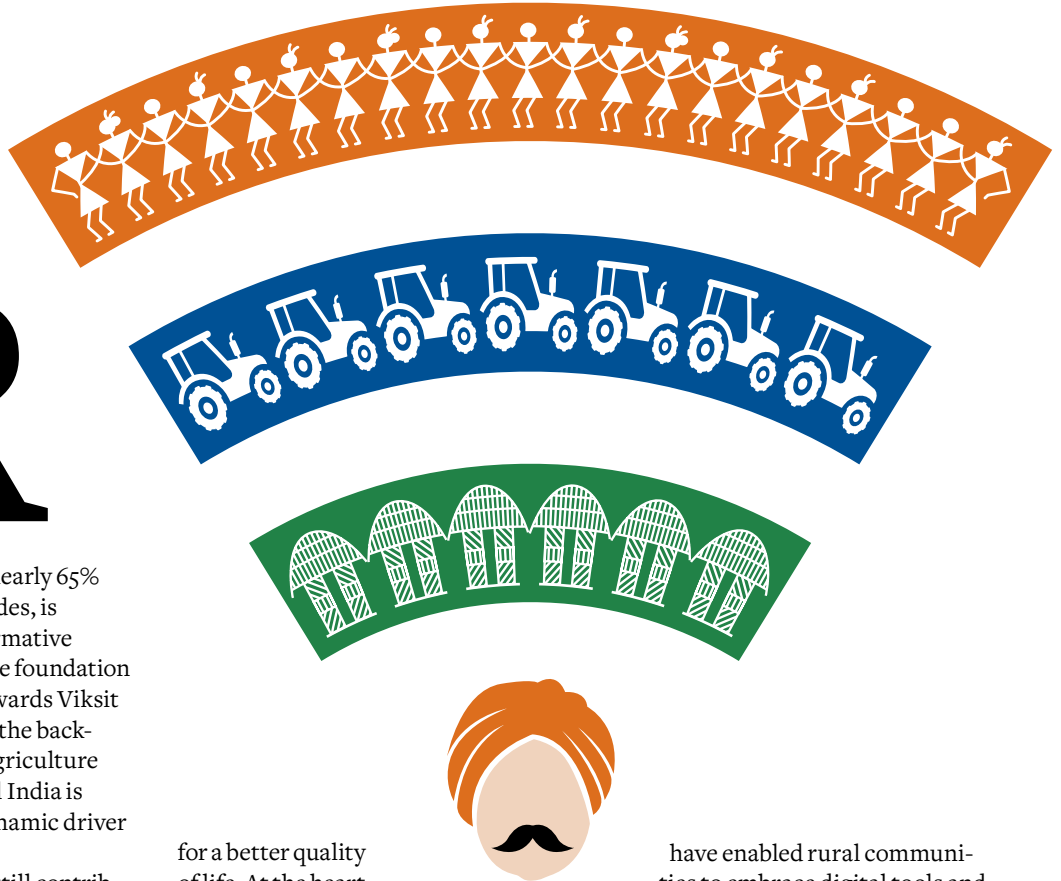




RURAL INDIA: NEW GROWTH LEADER

Addressing the pressing challenges of climate vulnerability, infrastructure gaps, and skill development will be essential to unlocking rural India's full potential

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RURAL INDIA, where nearly 65% of the population resides, is undergoing a transformative renaissance, laying the foundation for India's journey towards Viksit Bharat. Traditionally the backbone of the nation's agriculture and handicrafts, rural India is now emerging as a dynamic driver of economic growth.

While agriculture still contributes 15-18% to the national GDP (gross domestic product), rural areas are rapidly evolving beyond their agrarian roots. With rural consumption accounting for nearly 55% of total consumer spending, the demand for consumer goods such as two-wheelers, televisions, and smartphones is surging, often outpacing urban markets (PRICE's ICE360 survey, 2023). This transformation is fuelled by rising incomes, improved infrastructure, and growing aspirations

for a better quality of life. At the heart of this evolution lies the confluence of digital transformation, government welfare schemes, and entrepreneurial energy.

The digital revolution has brought connectivity and technology to the doorsteps of rural households. By 2024, rural India boasted over 360 million internet users, growing faster than urban regions in adoption rates. Affordable smartphones and data services, coupled with initiatives like Digital India,

have enabled rural communities to embrace digital tools and platforms. Apps like WhatsApp, with over 210 million Indian users, are now integral for communication, commerce, and even governance in villages. Social media platforms like Facebook and Instagram have empowered rural artisans, farmers, and businesses to connect with wider markets. Digital payments through platforms like UPI (Unified Payments Interface) have further integrated rural India into the formal economy, with 12 billion monthly transactions, a